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General Knowledge
Ancient History

STUDY NOTES

Travellers In Medieval India

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India, with its rich culture and history, has always intrigued travellers, especially during the medieval era. From the 10th to the 17th centuries, explorers, traders, and scholars embarked on remarkable journeys to India, recording their experiences and observations.

Notable among these were Al-Biruni from Persia, who documented India's science and customs; Ibn Battuta from Morocco, captivated by its diversity; and Marco Polo from Venice, who admired its wealth. Chinese pilgrim Xuanzang travelled for spiritual studies, while Niccolò de' Conti and François Bernier offered insights into its economy and politics. Their accounts provide valuable glimpses into mediaeval India's society and traditions.

Purpose and Significance of Travelling

- **Trade and commerce** attracted many travellers, particularly Arabs and Europeans, who sought India's abundant resources, including spices, textiles, and precious stones.
- **Diplomatic missions** were carried out by envoys aiming to establish alliances and foster relations with Indian rulers.
- **Religious pilgrimage** inspired travellers from China and Central Asia to visit sacred sites, especially Buddhist monasteries.
- **Exploration and curiosity** motivated adventurers like Marco Polo and Duarte Barbosa to uncover new lands and cultures.
- **Cultural documentation** was also a common goal, as travellers recorded India's social, economic, and political landscape. The spread of religion was furthered by Sufi saints and missionaries promoting Islam and Christianity across the subcontinent.

Table of Travellers in Medieval India

Name	Country	Period	Significant Points
Al-Masudi	Baghdad (Iraq)	915 AD	Documented **Indian culture** and **trade practices**.
Marco Polo	Italy	1288-1292 AD	Described **Kakatiya State** under Rudramadevi; provided early European accounts of southern India.
Niccolò de' Conti	Italy	1420-1421 AD	Wrote about **Vijayanagara's prosperity** during the rule of Devaraya I.
Cheng-He	China	1421-1431 AD	Travelled during the reign of **Jalaluddin** in Bengal.
Abdul Razzaq	Persia (Iran)	1442-1445 AD	Provided vivid accounts of **Vijayanagara's grandeur** under Devaraya II.
Afanasy Nikitin	Russia	1469-1472 AD	Documented **Bahamani Sultanate** in *Journey Beyond Three Seas*.
Bartolomeu Dias	Portugal	1488 AD	**First European to sail around the Cape of Good Hope**, opening the sea route to India.
Ludovico de Varthema	Italy	1502-1508 AD	Left **memoirs** documenting **Indian society**.
Duarte Barbosa	Portugal	1516-1518 AD	Described **trade** during the reign of **Krishnadevaraya** in southern India.
Domingo Paes	Portugal	1520-1522 AD	Documented the **wealth and life** of **Vijayanagara** under Krishnadevaraya.

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Fernao Nunes	Portugal	1535-1537 AD	Described the **Tuluvu dynasty** under **Achyuta Devaraya**.
Anthony Monserrate	Spain	1578-1582 AD	Travelled during **Akbar's reign** as a Jesuit missionary.
Ralph Fitch	England	1585-1591 AD	Describe **Akbar's court** and the **economic conditions** in India.
Caesar Frederick	Italy	16th Century AD	Wrote about **Vijayanagara's trade**.
John Liscontenten	Europe	16th Century AD	Travelled to **Vijayanagara Empire**.
Lama Taranath	Tibet	16th Century AD	Documented **East India** and **Buddhism**.
Ibn Battuta	Morocco	1333-1347 AD	Described **daily life** during the **Delhi Sultanate** and worked as a **Qadi** under Muhammad bin Tughlaq.
William Hawkins	England	1609-1611 AD	Ambassador of **King James I**, visited **Jahangir's court**.
William Fitch	England	1608-1612 AD	Travelled during **Jahangir's reign**.
John Jourdain	England	1608-1617 AD	Documented **Jahangir's administration**.
Thomas Roe	England	1615-1619 AD	Secured **trade privileges** for the **British East India Company**.
Paul Canning	England	1615-1625 AD	Came during the rule of **Jahangir** for diplomatic purposes.

Francisco Pelsaert	Netherlands	1620-1627 AD	Documented **economic conditions** during **Jahangir's reign**.
Pietro Della Valle	Italy	1622-1633 AD	Described **Mughal culture** during **Jahangir's reign**.
John Lait	England	1626-1633 AD	Travelled during **Shah Jahan's reign**.
Peter Mundy	England	1630-1634 AD	Wrote about **trade** and **Shah Jahan's governance**.
Jean-Baptiste Tavernier	France	1638-1663 AD	Documented **Mughal wealth, jewels, and architecture**.
François Bernier	France	1656-1668 AD	Critically analyzed **Aurangzeb's administration**.
Niccolò Manucci	Italy	1656-1687 AD	Provided critical accounts of **Aurangzeb's reign** and Indian customs.
Jean de Thévenot	France	1666-1668 AD	Travelled during **Aurangzeb's reign**.
Gemelli Careri	Italy	1695-1699 AD	Documented **Bijapur's trade** and governance.

Detail of Important Travellers

1. Ibn Battuta - Morocco (1333-1347 AD)

- Ibn Battuta travelled to India as a **judge (Qadi)** under the rule of **Muhammad bin Tughlaq**.
- His travelogue, **Rihla**, offers a comprehensive description of **court life and administration** in the **Delhi Sultanate**.
- He described the **trade networks, religious practices, and social customs** during the Sultanate period.

- His writings provide first-hand information about **Muhammad bin Tughlaq's eccentric policies** and India's **cultural diversity**.

2. Marco Polo - Italy (13th Century AD)

- Marco Polo visited **southern India** during his journey along the **Silk Route**.
- He documented the **trade activities** on the **Coromandel Coast** and **spice routes** that connected India with Europe and China.
- His travel records serve as one of the **earliest European accounts of Indian society**.
- Marco Polo highlighted the **rich textile industry, pepper trade, and religious diversity** of the region.

3. Abdur Razzaq - Persia (1442-1445 AD)

- Abdur Razzaq was sent as an **envoy by the Timurid Empire** to the **Vijayanagara Empire**.
- He described the **grandeur and prosperity** of the empire under **Deva Raya II**.
- His accounts emphasize the **religious tolerance** and **multicultural atmosphere** of the empire.
- He also noted the **administrative efficiency and architectural grandeur** of Vijayanagara's capital city.

4. Duarte Barbosa - Portugal (1500-1516 AD)

- Duarte Barbosa travelled as a **merchant and chronicler**, focusing on **India's coastal trade**.
- He provided detailed descriptions of **Calicut, Goa, and other coastal towns**, highlighting their **role in global trade networks**.
- Barbosa described the **customs, dress, and social structure** of the people in these regions.
- His records are valuable for understanding the **early Indo-Portuguese relations**.

5. Jean-Baptiste Tavernier - France (1638-1663 AD)

- Tavernier travelled to **India as a gem merchant**, dealing in **diamonds and precious stones**.

- His writings focus on **Mughal wealth, trade policies, and architecture** during the reign of **Shah Jahan**.
- Tavernier provided a detailed account of the **Taj Mahal's construction** and Mughal craftsmanship.
- His work offers insights into the **economic prosperity** of the Mughal Empire.

6. François Bernier - France (1656-1668 AD)

- Bernier came to India as a **physician and traveller**, spending several years at the Mughal court.
- His travelogue, **Travels in the Mughal Empire**, provides an **in-depth analysis of the Mughal administration**.
- Bernier compared the **Mughal political system** with European models, offering **critical observations**.
- His writings shed light on **Aurangzeb's reign**, focusing on **religious policies and military campaigns**.

7. Thomas Roe - England (1615-1619 AD)

- Thomas Roe was sent by **King James I** of England to establish **diplomatic relations** with the Mughal Empire.
- He successfully negotiated **trade privileges** for the **British East India Company**.
- Roe's letters and diaries provide valuable information about **Jahangir's court** and the **early phases of Anglo-Indian relations**.
- His mission laid the **foundation for future British influence** in India.

Contributions of Foreign Travellers to India

- Foreign travellers like **Megasthenes, Hiuen Tsang**, and **Ibn Battuta** documented **political events, administrative systems**, and **dynasties**, providing valuable historical insights into India during the **Mauryan, Delhi Sultanate, and Mughal periods**.
- Their accounts highlighted **social customs, religious festivals, art, and architecture**, offering a detailed picture of India's **cultural diversity and traditions**.
- Merchant travellers like **Niccolò de' Conti, Athanasius Nikitin**, and **Jean-Baptiste Tavernier** documented **India's trade routes, economic activities**, and **commercial practices**, emphasizing the significance of **spice trade and textiles**.

- Buddhist travellers such as **Fa-Hien** and **Hiuen Tsang** facilitated **religious exchanges** by documenting **Buddhist institutions, teachings, and practices**, fostering cross-cultural understanding between **India and Central Asia**.
- Travellers' vivid descriptions of **India's architectural marvels** like **temples, forts, palaces, and mosques** aided historians and archaeologists in **preserving these structures**.
- Foreign travellers provided **comparative perspectives** by observing and documenting **Indian governance, social norms, and traditions** through an **outsider's lens**, revealing differences between **Indian and European societies**.

Limitations of Foreign Travellers' Assessments

- Many foreign travellers viewed India through **a European lens**, often portraying **Indian customs and practices** as **backward** or **uncivilized**, as seen in the writings of **Niccolò Manucci**.
- Language barriers limited their understanding, resulting in **miscommunication and distorted portrayals** of **local traditions** and **social structures**.
- Foreign travellers focused predominantly on **elites, rulers, and administrative systems**, neglecting the **lives of ordinary people** and offering an incomplete picture of **society**.
- **Thomas Roe** documented only **Mughal imperial life** and the **nobility**, leaving out the experiences of common people.
- Some travellers, such as **Duarte Barbosa**, presented **oversimplified depictions** of Indian society by dividing the population into only **four castes**, overlooking the **complex hierarchies** within the caste system.
- Inaccuracies in their writings arose from **selective observations** and **personal biases**, impacting the authenticity of their assessments and limiting their contributions to **a partial understanding** of medieval India.